



Waved Through, Not Booked In

Hand-Signal Sequencing and the Loading Dock's Advance-Booking Forecast

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The problem

An advance-booking system sets the roller door's expected truck order, yet dock staff and couriers still negotiate live sequencing by hand signal whenever the yard runs ahead of or behind the booking. How closely does the signalled order track what the system forecast?

Research questions

- Document the hand-signal vocabulary dock staff and couriers use to sequence trucks at the roller door.
- Compare the signalled order against the booking system's published forecast, shift by shift.
- Identify the conditions under which staff default to signalling over the booked queue.

Study design

- 34 semi-structured interviews (18 dock staff, 16 couriers) · 3 bays · 9 weeks
- Interview coding cross-checked against dock CCTV and booking-system logs for the same shifts
- Coding scheme fixed before fieldwork; no post hoc recoding

Findings

Staff describe the hand-signal exchange as authoritative; the booking system's forecast functions as a suggestion, checked mainly when the yard is unusually quiet.



Concordance between the hand-signalled sequence and the forecast held at 31-37% across three bays through a mid-study notice-board upgrade (n = 41 shifts); no bay improved by more than 4 points.

Implications & takeaways

The hand-signal protocol functions as the dock's real scheduling layer; the forecast is checked mainly for capacity. Next: trial the signal vocabulary as the booking interface's own priority override.

Selected references

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“The wave beats the app to the door.”

62% of roller-door sequencing calls departed from the booking system's forecast (n = 41 shifts, 3 bays).